

Devices include a scanner alongside a printer. This enables them to act as a printer, a scanner and a photo-copy machine which can read a document via the scanner and print a copy using the printer. When choosing an MFD, getting one with a flat-bed scanner is better than getting one with a paper-feeder scanner. Flatbeds can be used to scan/copy thick document sets and books while the paper-feeder can accept only a single page for scanning.

Sound cards

The same music track sounds different when played on different machines using the same media playback software with same output settings. Audio processing on hardware level matters. If it matters enough to you, get a sound card. They can go into both PCI (conventional) or PCIe slots. Check the specifications and see if you have an empty slot on the board.

Optical drives

You might wonder why we are placing this component as an accessory and not an essential component. It's because they are coming of age. While on one end the Blu-ray and HD-DVD format wars were coming to an end, the average speed of internet was increasing with broadband access penetrating most of India and the world. Today, it is not difficult to get a 4Mbps connection in most parts of our country. You could download content worth a dual-layer DVD in a matter of hours. With various ISPs providing unlimited 10Mbps connections for as little as ₹800 per month, Internet connectivity has indeed become cheap. Optical discs are less and less in use (you must have noticed that now we ship only one DVD instead of two) and are no longer the preferred way of distributing software and media content. OS installations are increasingly being done using USB drives than DVDs and CD-ROMs. Cloud backups are becoming easier and faster than writing DVDs.

If however you do want to remain backward compatible, you can go for a good DVD-RW drive. Not just internal ones, but you also get external DVD drives that can be connected to the PC through a USB port. While Blu-Ray discs may be available (though only rarely seen anywhere), it makes more sense to get a DVD-RW drive than a Blu-Ray reader. It looks like Steve Jobs was right, after all. 